VOL3

VOLUME 3

Stretching & Relaxation Guide

80 gentle stretching and relaxation techniques for upper body, lower body, spinal mobility, and breathing.

80 Exercises | 4 Sections | All Levels | Stress Reduction

SENIOR ACTIVITY VAULT · PROFESSIONAL EDITION



SECTION 1

Upper Body Stretches

Neck, shoulder, chest, arm, and wrist stretches to relieve tension and maintain upper-limb range of motion.

- Neck tilts and rotations
- Shoulder and chest openers
- Forearm and wrist mobility
- Trap and upper back stretch





Neck Side Tilt

★ Independent

Gently tilt the ear toward the shoulder to release lateral neck tension.

1. Sit tall, shoulders relaxed.
2. Slowly lower right ear toward right shoulder.
3. Hold 20 seconds; feel the stretch on left neck.
4. Return to centre and repeat left side.



Neck Rotation

★ Independent

Rotate the head side to side to improve cervical mobility.

1. Sit upright, chin level.
2. Slowly turn head right as far as comfortable.
3. Hold 15 seconds.
4. Return to centre; rotate left; repeat 3 times each.



Chin Tuck

★ Independent

Draw the chin back to reduce forward head posture and relieve upper neck tension.

1. Sit or stand, eyes level.
2. Draw chin straight back (not down) — 'make a double chin'.
3. Hold 5 seconds.
4. Release; repeat 10 times.



Shoulder Roll

★ Independent

Roll shoulders backward and forward to mobilise the shoulder girdle and release tension.

1. Sit tall, arms relaxed.
2. Roll both shoulders slowly backward 5 times.
3. Roll forward 5 times.
4. Complete 3 sets.



Chest Opener

★ Independent

Open the chest by drawing elbows back to counteract forward shoulder posture.

1. Sit or stand, hands clasped behind back.
2. Squeeze shoulder blades together, lift chest.
3. Hold 20 seconds.
4. Release; repeat 5 times.



Cross-Body Shoulder Stretch

★ Independent

Bring one arm across the body to stretch the posterior shoulder.

1. Sit or stand, right arm extended.
2. Draw right arm across chest with left hand.
3. Hold 20 seconds; feel stretch in rear shoulder.
4. Switch arms; repeat 3 times each.



Overhead Tricep Stretch

★ Independent

Reach one hand down the back to stretch the tricep and shoulder.

1. Raise right arm overhead.
2. Bend elbow, dropping right hand behind head.
3. Left hand gently presses right elbow.
4. Hold 20 seconds; switch sides.



Forearm Flexor Stretch

★ Independent

Extend and gently bend the wrist back to stretch the forearm flexors.

1. Hold right arm forward, elbow straight, palm up.
2. With left hand, gently press fingers downward.
3. Hold 20 seconds; feel stretch in forearm.
4. Switch; repeat 3 times each side.



Forearm Extensor Stretch

★ Independent

Flex the wrist downward to stretch the forearm extensors.

1. Hold right arm forward, elbow straight, palm down.
2. With left hand, gently press fingers downward.
3. Hold 20 seconds.
4. Switch sides; repeat.



Wrist Circle

★ Independent

Circle both wrists to mobilise all wrist planes and improve hand circulation.

1. Hold arms forward, hands relaxed.
2. Circle both wrists slowly clockwise 10 times.
3. Circle counterclockwise 10 times.
4. Shake hands gently to release.



Trapezius Stretch

★ Independent

Anchor one shoulder down while tilting the head to stretch the upper trapezius muscle.

1. Sit tall, right hand holding chair seat to anchor shoulder.
2. Tilt left ear toward left shoulder.
3. Hold 25 seconds.
4. Switch sides; repeat 3 times.



Pectoral Corner Stretch

★★ Assisted

Stand in a doorway and lean forward to open the pectoral muscles.

1. Stand in doorway, forearms on door frame at shoulder height.
2. Lean body gently forward until chest opens.
3. Hold 25 seconds.
4. Step back; rest; repeat 4 times.



Thread the Needle

★★ Assisted

Slide one arm under the body from a four-point position to stretch the thoracic spine and shoulder.

1. Kneel on hands and knees on a mat.
2. Slide right arm under body, reaching left.
3. Lower right shoulder toward floor.
4. Hold 20 seconds; return; repeat left side.



Shoulder Pendulum

★ Independent

Let the arm hang and swing gently to decompress the shoulder joint.

1. Lean forward resting left hand on chair back.
2. Let right arm hang freely.
3. Gently swing arm forward-back 10 times, then side-side 10 times.
4. Switch sides.



Neck Forward Flex

★ Independent

Lower the chin to the chest to stretch the posterior neck muscles.

1. Sit tall, shoulders down.
2. Slowly lower chin toward chest.
3. Hold 20 seconds.
4. Return to neutral; repeat 5 times.



Upper Back Cat Stretch (Seated)

★ Independent

Round the upper back to stretch thoracic extensors while seated.

1. Sit at front of chair, hands on knees.
2. Round upper back, bringing chin toward chest.
3. Hold 15 seconds.
4. Return to tall sitting; repeat 8 times.



Bicep Doorway Stretch

★★ Assisted

Face away from a wall with one arm behind to stretch bicep and anterior shoulder.

1. Stand, right arm extended behind, palm against wall.
2. Step forward gently until front of shoulder stretches.
3. Hold 20 seconds.
4. Switch; repeat 3 times each.



Elbow Touch Behind Head

★ Independent

Place one hand on opposite shoulder blade to release the rear deltoid.

1. Raise right arm, bend elbow.
2. Touch right hand to left shoulder blade.
3. Left hand gently presses right elbow for deeper stretch.
4. Hold 20 seconds; switch sides.



Seated Side Reach

★ Independent

Reach one arm overhead to the opposite side to stretch the lateral torso.

1. Sit tall, left hand gripping chair seat.
2. Raise right arm overhead and lean right gently.
3. Hold 20 seconds.
4. Return; switch sides; repeat 3 times.



Finger Splay and Fist

★ Independent

Alternate between opening fingers wide and making a fist to mobilise the hand.

1. Hold hands forward, palms up.
2. Spread all fingers as wide as possible; hold 3 seconds.
3. Make a firm fist; hold 3 seconds.
4. Repeat 10 cycles.



SECTION 2

Lower Body Stretches

Hip, quadricep, hamstring, calf, and ankle stretches to maintain lower-limb flexibility for safe walking and transfers.

- Hip flexor and hamstring
- Quad and calf stretches
- Ankle and dorsiflexion
- Inner thigh and IT band





Seated Hip Flexor Stretch

★ Independent

Sit at the edge of chair and drop one leg back to stretch the hip flexor.

1. Sit at edge of chair, right foot flat.
2. Let left leg drop slightly behind.
3. Sit tall; feel stretch at front of left hip.
4. Hold 25 seconds; switch sides.



Seated Hamstring Stretch

★ Independent

Extend the leg and lean forward at the hips to stretch the hamstrings.

1. Sit at front of chair; extend right leg straight.
2. Flex right foot, sit tall.
3. Lean forward from hips (not waist) until hamstring pulls.
4. Hold 25 seconds; switch legs.



Quad Stretch Standing

★★ Assisted

Hold the ankle behind the body to stretch the front thigh.

1. Stand beside chair, left hand on back.
2. Bend right knee, holding ankle with right hand.
3. Keep knees together; stand tall.
4. Hold 25 seconds; switch legs.



Standing Calf Stretch

★ Independent

Step one foot back and press the heel down to stretch the calf muscle.

1. Stand facing wall, hands on wall.
2. Step right foot back 60 cm, keep heel on floor.
3. Bend left knee slightly.
4. Hold 25 seconds; switch legs.



Soleus Stretch

★ Independent

Bend the back knee in a calf stretch position to target the deeper soleus muscle.

1. Stand in split stance, right foot back.
2. Bend both knees slightly.
3. Press right heel down; hold 25 seconds.
4. Switch feet; repeat 3 times.



Ankle Alphabet

★ Independent

Trace the alphabet with the foot to mobilise all planes of ankle movement.

1. Sit, right foot lifted.
2. Slowly trace each letter A–Z with toes.
3. Keep movements slow and deliberate.
4. Switch foot; rest between.



Seated Piriformis Stretch

★★ Assisted

Cross the ankle over the knee to stretch the deep hip external rotators.

1. Sit upright, cross right ankle over left knee.
2. Sit tall; press right knee gently downward.
3. Lean forward slightly until right buttock stretches.
4. Hold 30 seconds; switch sides.



Inner Thigh Butterfly

★ Independent

Press knees outward from a seated position to stretch the hip adductors.

1. Sit at front of chair, feet wider than shoulder-width.
2. Let knees fall outward.
3. Lean forward from hips until inner thighs stretch.
4. Hold 25 seconds; repeat 5 times.



Lying Hip Flexor Stretch

★★ Assisted

Lie on back at the edge of a plinth and drop one leg down to stretch the hip flexor.

1. Lie on back on mat; bring both knees to chest.
2. Slowly lower left leg toward floor.
3. Hold right knee to chest.
4. Hold 30 seconds; switch legs.



IT Band Stretch Seated

★ Independent

Cross the leg and twist the torso to stretch the iliotibial band.

1. Sit tall, cross right foot over left knee.
2. Place left hand on right knee, right hand behind.
3. Gently twist right to look behind you.
4. Hold 25 seconds; switch sides.



Standing Hip Circle

★ Independent

Circling the hip in standing to mobilise the hip joint through full range.

1. Stand, hands on hips.
2. Circle hips in a large slow circle.
3. 5 circles clockwise, 5 counterclockwise.
4. Repeat.



Seated Toe Touch

★ Independent

Reach toward toes from a seated position for a gentle posterior chain stretch.

1. Sit at front of chair, feet flat.
2. Slide hands down legs toward toes.
3. Hold where you feel a light pull.
4. Hold 20 seconds; return upright.



Lying Knee Hug

★ Independent

Hug both knees to the chest while lying to gently stretch the lower back and hips.

1. Lie on back on mat.
2. Draw both knees to chest.
3. Wrap arms around shins and hug gently.
4. Hold 30 seconds; release slowly.



Standing Quad Stretch with Support

★★ Assisted

Hold a wall for support while performing a standing quad stretch to ensure safety.

1. Stand side-on to wall, left hand on wall.
2. Bend right knee, hold ankle with right hand.
3. Push hip slightly forward for deeper stretch.
4. Hold 25 seconds; switch sides.



Dorsiflexion Stretch

★ Independent

Pull the foot upward to stretch the Achilles and maintain ankle flexibility.

1. Sit with legs extended on mat.
2. Loop a towel around right foot.
3. Pull towel gently to flex foot toward body.
4. Hold 25 seconds; switch feet.



Hip Abductor Seated Stretch

★ Independent

Bring the foot across the body to stretch the outer hip and glute.

1. Sit, right ankle on left knee.
2. Sit tall; lean very slightly forward.
3. Feel stretch in right outer hip/glute.
4. Hold 30 seconds; switch sides.



Supine Hamstring Stretch

★ Independent

Lie on back and raise one leg with towel support for a supported hamstring stretch.

1. Lie on back, left leg bent.
2. Loop towel around right foot.
3. Raise right leg toward ceiling until stretch felt.
4. Hold 30 seconds; switch legs.



Standing Groin Stretch

★★ Assisted

Widen stance and shift weight to one side to stretch the inner thigh.

1. Stand with feet twice shoulder-width apart.
2. Shift weight to right side, bending right knee.
3. Keep left leg straight; feel stretch in left inner thigh.
4. Hold 25 seconds; switch sides.



Seated Calf Stretch

★ Independent

Extend the leg and flex the foot to stretch the calf while seated.

1. Sit at front of chair, right leg extended.
2. Flex right foot hard (toes back).
3. Place towel around foot and pull gently.
4. Hold 25 seconds; switch.



Hip Extension Lying

★★ Assisted

Lie face down and gently lift the leg to stretch the hip flexors and challenge hip extension.

1. Lie face down on mat.
2. Rest forehead on hands.
3. Lift right leg 10 cm off mat, keeping knee straight.
4. Hold 5 seconds; lower; 8 reps each leg.



SECTION 3

Spinal Mobility

Seated twists, cat-cow variations, side bends, and forward folds to maintain full spinal range and reduce back pain.

- Seated and floor cat-cow
- Trunk rotation and side bend
- Pelvic tilt and lumbar flex
- Thoracic extension work





Seated Trunk Rotation

★ Independent

Rotate the torso from side to side while seated to mobilise the thoracic spine.

1. Sit tall, arms crossed over chest.
2. Rotate torso right as far as comfortable.
3. Hold 10 seconds.
4. Rotate left; repeat 10 times each side.



Cat-Cow Seated

★ Independent

Alternate rounding and arching the back while seated to move the full spine.

1. Sit at front of chair, hands on knees.
2. Round back (cat): chin to chest, tailbone tucked.
3. Arch back (cow): chest forward, chin up.
4. Alternate 10 cycles, slow and controlled.



Seated Side Bend

★ Independent

Lean to the side while seated to lengthen the lateral trunk muscles.

1. Sit tall, left hand on chair seat.
2. Raise right arm and lean right.
3. Hold 20 seconds.
4. Return and repeat left; 3 times each.



Thoracic Extension on Roll

★★ Assisted

Extend the thoracic spine over a rolled towel to improve upper back mobility.

1. Roll a towel and place horizontally across chair back.
2. Sit in front of it so roll is at mid-back.
3. Gently extend backward over the roll.
4. Hold 15 seconds; reposition up 2 cm; repeat 4 positions.



Cat-Cow on Hands and Knees

★★ Assisted

The classic floor cat-cow for full spinal flexion and extension.

1. Kneel on hands and knees, wrists under shoulders.
2. Exhale: round back to ceiling.
3. Inhale: let back sag toward floor.
4. 10 cycles, moving slowly with breath.



Seated Forward Fold

★ Independent

Hinge forward from seated position to gently flex the entire spine.

1. Sit at front of chair, feet apart.
2. Let torso drop forward between knees, arms hanging.
3. Hold 25 seconds.
4. Roll upright slowly.



Trunk Lateral Shift

★★ Assisted

Shift the trunk sideways to one hip to practise lateral spinal mobility.

1. Stand feet hip-width apart, hands on hips.
2. Shift hips right while keeping shoulders level.
3. Hold 10 seconds.
4. Shift left; repeat 8 times each.



Seated Spinal Twist

★ Independent

Twist the spine with hands on knees for a gentle thoracolumbar rotation stretch.

1. Sit tall, feet flat.
2. Place right hand on left knee.
3. Turn torso left, looking over left shoulder.
4. Hold 20 seconds; switch direction.



Back Extension Standing

★ Independent

Stand and place hands on lower back, gently extending backward to counter flexion posture.

1. Stand feet hip-width, hands on lower back.
2. Slowly arch backward from waist.
3. Hold 10 seconds.
4. Return upright; repeat 8 times.



Pelvic Tilt

★ Independent

Rock the pelvis forward and back while seated to mobilise the lumbar spine.

1. Sit at front of chair, hands on hips.
2. Tilt pelvis forward (arch lower back).
3. Tilt pelvis back (flatten lower back).
4. Alternate 15 times slowly.



Supine Knee Rocks

★ Independent

Rock bent knees from side to side while lying to gently rotate the lumbar spine.

1. Lie on back on mat, knees bent.
2. Let both knees fall right slowly.
3. Return to centre, then fall left.
4. Repeat 15 times each side.



Quadruped Thoracic Rotation

★★ Assisted

Open the chest toward the ceiling from a four-point kneeling position.

1. Kneel on hands and knees.
2. Place right hand behind head, elbow out.
3. Rotate right elbow toward left arm.
4. Open elbow toward ceiling; 8 reps each.



Seated Lumbar Flexion

★ Independent

Tuck the pelvis to gently flex the lower back and reduce stiffness.

1. Sit tall at front of chair.
2. Round lower back by tucking tailbone under.
3. Hold 15 seconds.
4. Return to neutral; repeat 10 times.



Side-Lying Trunk Stretch

★★ Assisted

Lie on the side and rotate the top arm back to open the chest and spine.

1. Lie on left side on mat, knees bent.
2. Extend both arms in front.
3. Slowly rotate right arm back to reach behind.
4. Follow with gaze; hold 20 seconds; switch sides.



Prayer Stretch

★ Independent

Reach arms forward on the floor from a kneeling position to stretch the thoracic spine.

1. Kneel on mat, then sit back toward heels.
2. Reach arms forward on the floor.
3. Lower forehead toward floor if comfortable.
4. Hold 30 seconds.



Cobra Preparation

★★ Assisted

Gentle upper spinal extension from lying face down to improve thoracic mobility.

1. Lie face down on mat.
2. Place hands at shoulders.
3. Press up onto forearms, lifting chest slightly.
4. Hold 15 seconds; lower; repeat 5 times.



Segmental Roll-Down

★★ Assisted

Roll the spine down vertebra by vertebra to increase spinal mobility awareness.

1. Stand upright, arms relaxed.
2. Begin by lowering chin to chest.
3. Roll down one segment at a time, arms hanging.
4. Slowly roll back up; repeat 5 times.



Knee-to-Chest Single

★ Independent

Draw one knee toward the chest to gently stretch the lower back unilaterally.

1. Lie on back on mat.
2. Draw right knee toward chest.
3. Wrap arms around shin.
4. Hold 25 seconds; switch legs.



Supine Piriformis Stretch

★★ Assisted

Figure-four stretch lying on back to release deep hip rotators and lumbar tension.

1. Lie on back, right ankle on left knee.
2. Lift left foot off floor, hands around left thigh.
3. Draw legs toward chest.
4. Hold 30 seconds; switch sides.



Bridge with Spinal Articulation

★★ Assisted

Peel the spine off the mat vertebra by vertebra while rising into a bridge to mobilise the lumbar.

1. Lie on back on mat, knees bent.
2. Press heels down and peel spine off mat segment by segment.
3. Hold bridge 5 seconds.
4. Lower one segment at a time; repeat 8 times.



SECTION 4

Breathing & Relaxation

Box breathing, progressive muscle relaxation, guided imagery, and sound bath techniques for stress reduction and breath control.

- Box and belly breathing
- Progressive relaxation
- Visualisation exercises
- Mindful breath anchors



Box Breathing

★ Independent

Inhale, hold, exhale, and hold for equal counts to calm the nervous system.

1. Sit tall, shoulders relaxed.
2. Inhale for 4 counts.
3. Hold breath for 4 counts.
4. Exhale for 4 counts; hold 4 counts; repeat 5 cycles.

Belly Breathing

★ Independent

Direct breath into the abdomen to activate diaphragmatic breathing.

1. Sit or lie, one hand on belly.
2. Breathe in slowly through nose; feel belly rise.
3. Exhale fully; feel belly fall.
4. Continue for 10 deep breaths.

4-7-8 Breath

★ Independent

Inhale for 4, hold 7, exhale for 8 to activate the relaxation response.

1. Sit tall; close eyes.
2. Inhale through nose for 4 counts.
3. Hold breath for 7 counts.
4. Exhale through mouth for 8 counts; repeat 4 cycles.

Pursed-Lip Breathing

★ Independent

Exhale through pursed lips to slow the breath and improve oxygen exchange.

1. Sit tall, relax shoulders.
2. Inhale through nose for 2 counts.
3. Pucker lips as if blowing a candle.
4. Exhale slowly for 4 counts; repeat 10 times.

Progressive Muscle Relaxation

★ Independent

Tense and release each muscle group systematically to release physical tension.

1. Sit or lie comfortably.
2. Tense right hand and forearm 5 seconds.
3. Release suddenly; notice relaxation for 10 seconds.
4. Continue up the body: arm, shoulder, neck, face, down to feet.

Guided Body Scan

★ Independent

Mentally scan the body from feet to head, releasing tension at each area.

1. Lie or sit comfortably; close eyes.
2. Bring attention to feet; consciously relax them.
3. Move attention up: ankles, calves, knees, thighs.
4. Continue through hips, belly, chest, arms, neck, face.

Alternate Nostril Breathing

★★ Assisted

Breathe through one nostril at a time to balance nervous system activity.

1. Sit tall; right thumb closes right nostril.
2. Inhale through left nostril for 4 counts.
3. Close left nostril with ring finger; release thumb.
4. Exhale through right 4 counts; repeat 6 cycles.

Sound Bath Relaxation

★ Independent

Listen to recorded singing bowl or nature sounds to induce deep relaxation.

1. Sit or lie comfortably; close eyes.
2. Play singing bowl or nature sound recording softly.
3. Focus on the sound, allowing thoughts to pass.
4. Continue for 10 minutes.

Colour Breath Visualisation

★ Independent

Inhale imagining a calming colour and exhale tension as a different colour.

1. Sit comfortably; close eyes.
2. Imagine a soft blue light; inhale it into your body.
3. Exhale gray air carrying tension away.
4. Continue 10 breaths.

Mindful Stretch Breath

★ Independent

Coordinate a gentle arm raise with inhalation and lowering with exhalation.

1. Sit tall, arms at sides.
2. Inhale slowly, raising arms out and up overhead.
3. Exhale slowly, lowering arms to sides.
4. Repeat 8 times; feel breath and movement link.

Warm Hands Breath

★ Independent

Rub hands together and place over the face while exhaling to release tension.

1. Sit comfortably.
2. Rub palms together briskly for 10 seconds.
3. Cup warm hands over closed eyes.
4. Take 5 long slow exhalations into palms.

Sighing Breath

★ Independent

Take a deep inhale followed by a loud audible sigh to release stress.

1. Sit or stand; take the deepest breath possible.
2. Open mouth and exhale in one big audible sigh.
3. Let shoulders drop as you exhale.
4. Repeat 5 times.

Laughing Breath

★ Independent

Practise fake laughing breaths to stimulate the diaphragm and boost mood.

1. Sit in a circle if in a group.
2. Begin with forced 'Ha-Ha-Ha' exhalations.
3. Allow the absurdity to produce genuine smiles or laughter.
4. Continue 1 minute.

Breath Counting

★ Independent

Count each exhale up to 10 and repeat to practise sustained attention through breath.

1. Sit tall; close eyes.
2. Breathe naturally; count each exhale.
3. When you reach 10, begin again from 1.
4. Continue 5 minutes; note when mind wanders.

Candle Blow

★ Independent

Imagine blowing out birthday candles with long controlled exhalations.

1. Sit tall; take a deep breath.
2. Pucker lips as if blowing out a candle.
3. Exhale slowly and evenly for 8 counts.
4. Repeat 5 candles.

Lung Expansion Breathing

★ Independent

Breathe into each section of the lungs — belly, ribs, then chest — in sequence.

1. Sit tall; place one hand on belly, one on chest.
2. Inhale filling belly first.
3. Continue inhaling to expand ribs.
4. Finally top up chest; exhale fully; repeat 5 times.

Seated Mindful Posture Reset

★ Independent

Mindfully align the spine and shoulders between activities to reduce held tension.

1. Sit at front of chair.
2. Feel both sitting bones on seat.
3. Stack spine tall; relax shoulders.
4. Take 3 slow breaths in this posture.

Nature Sound Relaxation

★ Independent

Listen to a recording of nature sounds and describe what you hear to engage relaxation.

1. Play a 5-minute nature soundscape (rain, birds, waves).
2. Sit or lie comfortably; close eyes.
3. Mentally note the sounds you identify.
4. Share one image the sounds brought to mind.

Breath Bead Counting

★ Independent

Slide a bead along a string with each breath to give breath-counting a tactile anchor.

1. Prepare a string with 10 beads.
2. For each inhalation, slide one bead to the right.
3. When all 10 are moved, reverse direction on exhale.
4. Complete 3 rounds.

Cooling Breath

★ Independent

Inhale through a curled tongue to cool and calm the body on hot or anxious days.

1. Curl tongue into a tube (or breathe through teeth).
2. Inhale slowly through the curled tongue.
3. Close mouth; exhale through nose.
4. Repeat 8 times.